



Kurt Smith, portraying Thomas Jefferson, prepares for a program at the St. George Tucker House in Colonial Williamsburg in mid-July.

line of his life, shaped by deep studies in philosophy, the law, science and the Enlightenment, gradually led him to question much about British rule.

As one who benefited from much about the colonial system — and whose comfort depended in part on enslaved people propping up his plantations — Jefferson continued to hope that raising objections would suffice. But Jefferson's alarm was growing; his ire returned repeatedly to Parliament imposing its will on the colonies without local input. One unlikely spur emboldening Jefferson came from an Italian immigrant, Philip Mazzei, whom he was encouraging to build a vineyard near Monticello. Mazzei was naturalized as a colonist citizen and dined with Dunmore, whom he viewed as having a weak mind and a mean heart. He told Jefferson that the British would continue to enact abusive policies unless the colonists armed themselves for a possible revolt.

Jefferson was shocked at the suggestion. But when Mazzei asked Jefferson to help him publish a letter on the subject in the *Virginia Gazette*, Jefferson agreed on the condition that his identity be kept secret. The anonymous letter was published and foreshadowed much of what was to come. "All men are by nature equally free and independent," the letter said. "Such equality is necessary in order to create a free government. All men must be the equal to each other in natural law." In Jefferson's interpretation, this

meant equality between colonists and those living in Britain, and was not contradicted by slavery — a system that Mazzei opposed. (Years later, Congress passed a resolution crediting Mazzei with inspiring Jefferson's phrase that "all men are created equal," although some historians disputed this origin story).

The power of the *Virginia Gazette* was clear to Jefferson; this was an era of increasing literacy among White people when newspapering and pamphleteering would prove crucial to gathering support for his increasingly radical ideas. As he wrote years later, "were it left to me to decide whether we should have a government without newspapers or newspapers without a government, I should not hesitate a moment to prefer the latter. but I should mean that every man should receive those papers & be capable of reading them."

JEFFERSON, MEANWHILE, faced financial difficulties that were little known at the time. He spent far beyond his means to create the luxurious villa and plantations; he failed to collect many of the fees owed to him for legal work; and he was entangled in legal disputes and debt over his inheritance. Fair or not, he blamed many of his troubles on British policies, which further pushed him in a revolutionary direction.

The 13 colonies were fiefdoms of differing

interests, with varying amounts of enslavement, which was more predominant in the South. But all regions were feeling the effects of London's taxes and restrictions as a recession buffeted British America. Many Southern plantation owners were deeply in debt to British traders, and the value of their holdings declined in part because of laws imposed by London.

In Massachusetts, meanwhile, anger had been growing against British policies that would undermine the charter that formed the colony. British ships carried tea into Boston Harbor under a new policy that cut out American agents. The price of tea actually declined under London's actions, contrary to some popular perceptions then and now, but Massachusetts protesters still felt Parliament acted without their consent. Bostonians dressed as members of the Mohawk tribe dumped 342 crates of tea, prompting London to blockade the harbor. London responded with punitive actions that expanded the power of Parliament over British America. A group of Americans in May 1774 wrote a petition to the British government against the measures, which they said would reduce the colonists to "being totally enslaved."

Jefferson was outraged. He feared London's next target could be Virginia, which accounted for 40 percent of exports from British America. Until that point, the colonies rarely took united action. But now, as Jefferson wrote in his autobiography, he believed Virginia "must